Next of Kin

by Jane Nicolaas



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SARAH. Wake up. It's time to eat.
JANE. I don't want to.
SARAH. Well, sorry. You have to.
JANE. Like you care.
SARAH. About you? No. About your husband? Yes.
JANE. How is he? Where is he?
SARAH. He's stable. But still in the ICU.
JANE. How long will he be in there?
SARAH. Until he gets better.
JANE. Why are you here, Sarah?
SARAH. Because I can't be in there, Jane. Now…
(*gestures to the food*)
JANE. I didn't see the truck.
SARAH. I know you didn't see the truck. If you would have seen it, you wouldn't have hit it.
JANE. You still think this is my fault.
SARAH. You know, of all the things that I blame you for, this is shockingly not one of them.
JANE. Thank you…I guess.
SARAH. I'm not doing it for you.

INTRO

JANE. I don't like uncomfortable silences.
SARAH. Then go to sleep.
JANE. I'd like to talk. With you. I mean, I know it's not a great time to do this, but I'd like to just the same. I have questions.
SARAH. Such as?
JANE. Did you ever worry that he was cheating on you?
SARAH. You mean, "*Did I worry while he was cheating on me with you?"* Not particularly. I was always busy and I wasn't around much, so I didn't have a lot of free time to speculate and suspect.
JANE. I've worried about it.
SARAH. Makes sense.
JANE. I've worried about it with you. I mean, he still loves you. He always will. Even all that hatred during the divorce was only possible because of

how much you meant to each other. And with you two recently becoming close again…

SARAH. I told you it made sense.

JANE. Way to put my mind at ease, Sarah.

SARAH. That's not why I'm here. But there's nothing to be jealous of.

JANE. Easy for you to say. You don't know what it's like to be married to Sarah's ex-husband.

SARAH. Yeah, sure.

JANE. He tells me stories sometimes. Like how he proposed. How he hid the ring in a chocolate covered strawberry. How you cracked your tooth on it when you bit down. How you said you would only marry him if he could find you a tweny-four-hour dentist. Not an easy act to follow.

SARAH. You make it sound like *Grey's Anatomy*. It wasn't romantic at the time; it was painful and he was ticked off about it.

JANE. He never said that.

SARAH. Well, you know as well as I do that Sam's memory is somewhat selective. Besides, he told me that he proposed to you on a bridge on Christmas Eve with a puppy.

JANE. I told him I didn't want a ring.

SARAH. Clearly he had some romance left over for you.

JANE. I was allergic to the dog. We had to give him away.

SARAH. His romance is a very rare vintage.

(*pause*)

JANE. Did he…ever tell you how we met?

SARAH. No. I don't know if I was ever brave enough to ask.

JANE. It was at a book signing for Francis Anderson.

SARAH. Francis Anderson?

JANE. Yeah, it was for you. He told me while we were waiting in line. Said he hated Anderson with a passion and the only reason he could even stand to be in the same room with the windbag was to get a signed book for his wife. For Christmas.

SARAH. Yeah.

JANE. I fell in love with him then. A man who would stand in line for hours on end waiting on an author he hates just for a scribble for the woman he loves.

SARAH. He gave it to me the second he got home. Couldn't wait until Christmas, I guess.

JANE. I know. He said he worried that you would go get the book yourself so…he had to ruin the surprise.

SARAH. Thank you. I…I didn't know that part of the story. God, I even remember the fight we had about that book. I didn't get what the big deal was and I had to go to a meeting and… It's weird to know the day you started seeing my husband.

JANE. It wasn't like that. We really were just friends.

SARAH. Until you weren't.

JANE. Until we weren't. Sorry.

SARAH. Bit late for that.

JANE. But you two are hanging out again, right?

SARAH. Not really the word for it. We have lunch once a week. It's…nice.

JANE. Just nice?

SARAH. Honey, sometimes familiar and nice are the best a thing can be. When you're done being twenty-six and get a little closer to my age, I think you'll understand that.

JANE. Fifteen years is not all that much of a difference.

SARAH. Fourteen.

JANE. It's just time. That's what Sam always says, "It's just time."

SARAH. Ha! As if Sam was a reliable source on this one.

JANE. Meaning?

SARAH. Ok, who were you fifteen years ago?

JANE. An eleven-year-old.

SARAH. Uck. Whatever. Was that person the same person you are now?

JANE. Legally.

SARAH. No way. You and that girl wouldn't even know each other face-to-face. Time is the decisions you make, the mistakes, the relationships, the days, the trips, the scars. I don't expect that to make sense to you yet.

JANE. You don't have to be old…

SARAH. (*gives her a hard look*)

JANE. …er to understand that. Time is the only thing that separates you from being dead.

SARAH. Exactly. Time is what it takes to grow up, to grow apart.

JANE. Or to grow back together?

SARAH. Huh?

JANE. He's been happier lately. I can see it.

SARAH. And you think it's me? Believe me, Sam's happiness has rarely--if ever--been the result of me.

JANE. You two…you're…in love again.

SARAH. No, we're not and we won't be.

JANE. Why not?

SARAH. Why are you even asking that?

JANE. Because you love him.

SARAH. Of course I do. Do you honestly think I'd be nursing my ex-husband's mistress-slash-new wife if I didn't still love him?

JANE. So…?

SARAH. So what? What do you want me to do?

JANE. Admit it. Admit that you love him.

SARAH. I have. I do.

JANE. And admit that you think this whole thing is my fault.

SARAH. Fine.

JANE. And that you're hoping that you can use this to make him come back to you.

SARAH. Jane. No.

JANE. It's ok. I totally get it.

SARAH. Clearly you don't.

JANE. You're fighting to get him back.

SARAH. Nope. Already tried that. I lost. Remember?

JANE. So you just give up? You quit?

SARAH. Look, I don't know what kind of brain damage you sustained in the crash, but you do realize you are actively coaching me to try to steal your husband, right?

JANE. So you're thinking about it then? You're thinking about doing it?

SARAH. Just shut up. Ok? Shut up. This may be hard for you to understand, but sometimes it's not about winning or stealing. Sometimes it's just about fighting for someone's happiness…even if it's not your own. You make Sam happy. I'm trying to keep you alive and calm until he comes out of that stupid ICU. Simple as that.

JANE. Simple as that? You expect me to just accept that you are here out of some weird altruism? Sorry, nobody is that selfless.

SARAH. Well, it's selfless or helpless and either way I'm less for it.

JANE. That was weirdly poetic.

SARAH. Yeah, well, I've been looking at get well soon cards all morning, sort of short-circuits your sentiment maker.

(*pause*)

JANE. I have to tell you something.

SARAH. Is that something the reason why you are pursuing this ridiculous conversation?

JANE. I know you blame me for your marriage failing.

SARAH. God, do you ever shut up?

JANE. Neither of us–him or me--we never wanted to hurt you.

SARAH. Ok, you've said your something. Asked your questions. I think it's time for you to stop talking now.

JANE. I want your forgiveness.

SARAH. Why?

JANE. Because I think…if you can forgive me. Then I'll know you're not trying to steal my husband.

SARAH. You mean steal back my husband? And what if I am? What if that's exactly what I'm doing here?

JANE. I can't say I'd blame you.

SARAH. What would you say?

JANE. I'd say, "I told you so."

SARAH. Look Jane, I give up, ok? Obviously I can't tell you this in a way you'll believe. So…

JANE. Just promise me you'll take care of him.

SARAH. God, you're like a stubborn two-year-old. I am not trying to—

JANE. Promise me that you'll take care of him and that you'll keep him safe.

SARAH. Safe? God, you sound like you're trying to *give* your husband to me.

JANE. It's just like you said. When you love someone you fight for his happiness.

SARAH. Jane, grow up. Get your head out of your ass.

JANE. Of all people I would think you would understand this.

SARAH. Well, I don't. Do you think he's just some puppy you can give away?

JANE. No.

SARAH. You think that since you stole him so easily he's easy to pass around?

JANE. No.

SARAH. You're damn right no. Sam is impetuous and self-righteous and overly sentimental, but he's a good guy. He deserves better than to be put up for some sort of husband adoption.

JANE. What do you want me to do, Sarah? I'd rather give him up willingly than watch him leave. I don't want…

SARAH. What?

JANE. I don't want to become you! Some pissed off woman who hangs around her ex's new wife for some weird feeling of superiority.

SARAH. That's not what I'm doing.

JANE. What is it, then? Are you here to tell me how stupid he was? How much better off he'd be with you? 'Cuz I know all of that. You think a stupid woman who drives into a parked car doesn't know how much better off her husband would've been if she had just let him stand alone at a book signing? I already feel guilty.

SARAH. For God's sake, so do I! Why is this all about you? Why *must* it be about Sam? Maybe I didn't want to become me either. Nobody wants to be the pissed off woman who was too busy for her own marriage. Hate to break it to you missy, but letting him go willingly and watching him leave…I've done both and they both suck. So just…shut the hell up, ok?

JANE. (*realizes*) You're not here to steal him back. You're here because…because you weren't there before. Is that is?

SARAH. Congratulations. What do you want, a prize?

JANE. Wow.

SARAH. Better late than never, right?

JANE. That's really…amazing.

SARAH. Don't go nuts, ok? It's not like I'm giving him a kidney or something. I'm just…here.

JANE. Sometimes here is the best a person can be.

SARAH. Yeah.

(*pause*)

JANE. I'm sorry I yelled at you.

SARAH. Don't worry about it.

JANE. And thank you for yelling at me. I guess I needed that.

SARAH. Don't mention it.

JANE. And I'm sorry I tried to…give you my husband.

SARAH. Ha. *Definitely* don't mention that one. Sam'd be pissed.

JANE. He'd be livid.

BOTH. He'd probably cry.

SARAH. Maybe we'll call it temporary insanity.

JANE. Or a head injury.

SARAH. Or a medicinal side effect.

(*both laugh*)

JANE. We were both wrong before, you know. You're not just a pissed off ex-wife. You're a good person, Sarah. I can see why he loves you so much.

SARAH. And you are a pain in the ass. I can see why he loves *you* so much.

JANE. I'm glad you're here.

SARAH. Strangely, me too. And as far as that forgiveness thing goes. No, you can't have it. You don't need it. You were there when I wasn't. No wrong in that.

JANE. Thank you.

SARAH. Yeah, well. Like I said, I'm not doing it for you. Not *just* for you, anyway.